

How Long Does It Last?

Category	Guessing game - Shelf life - Table engagement
Skill level	Beginner - "Grab & go." The food item, both shelf lives, and the explanation are all on the card / screen. No food-preservation expertise needed.
Audience	All ages - every item has a kid, tween, teen, and adult explanation. The big flip-board version is great for drawing a crowd.
Setup time	5-10 minutes

DESCRIPTION

A "wow" guessing game: a visitor sees a food item (e.g., Strawberry Jam) and guesses how long it lasts FRESH vs. PRESERVED. The reveal shows both shelf lives with a comparison bar, a surprising fact, and an age-appropriate explanation. 40 items across 8 topics, chosen for surprising differences (and a few trick items where fresh lasts longer than people expect).

MATERIALS NEEDED

Digital version (tablet)

- A tablet open to the game: sign in to the MFP Volunteer Resource Hub, tap "Toolkit," then "Play on tablet" on the How Long Does It Last? card. Use the age dropdown so the explanation matches the player.

Printed version (no technology needed)

- The "question-cards.pdf" deck (40 cards): front = the food item + guess prompt; back = the fresh vs. preserved comparison bars, the surprising fact, and a safety note.
- The large "flip-board.pdf" for a table easel - big front (food + guess) and back (the answer), great for a crowd.
- The "Volunteer Key" (volunteer-key.pdf) - every item with both shelf lives, the surprising fact, all four age explanations, and the source.

Both versions

- Table, tablecloth, and MFP / OSU Extension signage; optional take-home educational handouts.
- This Activity Guide on the table.

SETUP

1. Decide digital, printed cards, the big flip-board, or a mix.
2. Printed: print "question-cards.pdf" double-sided (flip on the SHORT edge) and cut, and/or print "flip-board.pdf" and stand it on an easel. Print the Volunteer Key and keep it handy.
3. Digital: charge the tablet, open the game, pick the age level, and try one item.

ACTIVITY DIRECTIONS

Running it

1. Show the food item and ask the visitor to GUESS: how long does it last fresh? How long preserved?
2. Let them commit to a guess out loud - that is what makes the reveal fun.
3. Reveal the answer (tap "Reveal answer" on the tablet, or flip the card / board).
4. Point at the comparison bars and read the surprising fact. Read the explanation that fits their age.
5. Mention the safety note if there is one, then move to the next item.

VOLUNTEER NOTES

- No expertise needed - the answer, the surprising fact, and the explanation are all on the card/screen.
- The fun is the guess. Always let people guess before you reveal.
- Some items are "trick" items where fresh lasts longer than expected or preserved has nuance ("best quality" vs. still safe) - lean into the surprise.
- Accuracy matters: read the numbers and notes as written; do not improvise storage advice. Refer deeper questions to a Master Food Preserver.
- For little ones, use the Kids explanation and keep it to the big idea (preserving makes food last much longer).
- No tablet? The printed cards and flip-board play exactly the same.
- There are no prizes - the "wow" and the conversation are the point.
- Simple tablet help: tap "Reveal answer," then "Next." It works without internet once open. Keep it charged.